5 The Palestinian Problem

POINTS TO CONSIDER
This chapter will focus on the Palestinian problem: the problem of a people without a home. It will examine the plight of the refugees and the rise of the PLO. It will show how PLO military activities led to the Israeli invasion of Lebanon and, finally, it will study the origins and impact of the Palestinian *Intifada* (uprising). These developments are covered under the following headings:

- The Palestine Liberation Organisation
- War in Lebanon
- The Palestinian *Intifada* 1987–93

Key dates

1959	Fatah set up
1964	Formation of the PLO
1967	Six-Day War
1968	The 'Battle of Karameh'
1969	Arafat became Chairman of the PLO
1970	PLO expelled from Jordan
1972	Israeli athletes killed at the Olympic Games
1978 and 1982	Israeli invasions of Lebanon
1987–93	Palestinian *Intifada*

1 | The Palestine Liberation Organisation

The Palestinian refugees

Key question
What were conditions like in the refugee camps?

During the fighting between Israel and the Arabs in 1948–9, over 700,000 Arabs fled from their homes in Palestine. As you can see on the map on page 77, most of them went to the West Bank or the Gaza Strip. Large numbers also went to Syria, Jordan and Lebanon. Today the UN reckons there are about four million Palestinian refugees.

After the war ended in 1949 the UN formed the UN Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA). This body set up camps for the refugees and provided food, clothing, shelter and education. At first, the refugees lived in tents, later in huts made of mud, corrugated iron or concrete. The camps became the shanty towns of the